

Joint Pain & Stiffness, Including Arthritis & Gout

The most common ailment characterized by joint pain and stiffness is arthritis, which is caused by inflammation of the joints. Aging or wear and tear may be the cause, but some arthritic conditions, and other joint problems such as gout, are due to the buildup of waste products in the joints.

Devil's claw is anti-inflammatory, relieving swollen and inflamed joints.

Lemon juice reduces acidity in the body. White willow relieves inflammation and pain and, when combined with other herbs, can lead to significant improvement in mild to moderate arthritis.

Meadowsweet and celery combine well to reduce acidity. All the herbal remedies here can be safely taken for 1–2 months.

Self-help

Improving posture, managing anxiety, and using herbal remedies to help the body eliminate toxins can all help control these conditions. Avoid acid-forming foods such as red meat, spinach, tomatoes, and oranges. Regular (but not excessive) exercise is beneficial, as is a relaxed, positive attitude.

❗ **General cautions** For severe arthritis, consult a professional practitioner. Do not take devil's claw, black cohosh, or celery seed during pregnancy.

Arthritis & Inflamed Joints

Herb Devil's claw (*Harpagophytum procumbens*, p. 103)

Remedy Take tablets (see *General cautions*).

Herb Lemon (*Citrus limon*, p. 82)

Remedy Squeeze the juice from a lemon and drink neat or diluted in water each morning.

Herb White willow (*Salix alba*, p. 129)

Remedy Take tablets, or make a decoction using 10 g of root to 3 cups (750 ml) water. Take in 3 doses over 1–2 days as required.

Herbs Devil's claw (*Harpagophytum procumbens*, p. 103), celery (*Apium graveolens*, p. 64), white willow (*Salix alba*, p. 129)

Remedy Make a decoction with 8 g of each herb to 3 cups (750 ml) of water; divide into 4 doses, and take 2–3 doses a day; or mix equal parts of the tinctures and take 1 tsp with water 3 times a day (see *General cautions*).

Option If arthritis develops during menopause, replace devil's claw with 8 g of black cohosh (*Cimicifuga racemosa*, p. 79)

Herb Deadly nightshade (*Atropa belladonna*, p. 69)

Remedy Apply belladonna bandages in addition to one of the above remedies.

Arthritis Associated with Acid Indigestion or Peptic Ulcer

Herbs Meadowsweet (*Filipendula ulmaria*, p. 98), celery (*Apium graveolens*, p. 64)

Remedy Make an infusion with meadowsweet and drink up to 3 cups (750 ml) a day, or mix 2 parts meadowsweet tincture with 1 part celery tincture and take ½ tsp with water 2–3 times a day (refer to *General cautions*).

Stiff & Aching Joints

Herbs St. John's wort (*Hypericum perforatum*, p. 106), comfrey (*Symphytum officinale*, p. 138), lavender (*Lavandula officinalis*, p. 108)

Remedy Mix 2½ tbsp of St. John's wort or comfrey infused oil with 20–40 drops of lavender essential oil and gently massage into the affected area.

Option Try the rub containing St. John's wort infused oil under *General Remedies for Back Pain* below.

Gout

Herb Celery (*Apium graveolens*, p. 64)

Remedy Take tablets, or make a decoction with the seeds. Divide into 3 doses and drink during the day or add 25 g of seeds to food per day (see *General cautions*).

Back Pain

Above all, back problems require specialist attention and plenty of rest. Herbal remedies contribute to overall improvement by alleviating pain and muscle tension, and helping to make life more comfortable.

Cramp bark and prickly ash are warming, relaxing herbs, which, when rubbed into the affected area, help to “unknot” taut muscles.

Lavender and St. John's wort are useful herbs when nervous tension is contributing to the problem.

Devil's claw and cramp bark have effective anti-inflammatory properties and help reduce swollen joints.

Passionflower encourages sleep, particularly when back pain is accompanied by nervous tension.

Sciatica (a painful condition caused by a trapped spinal nerve) and neuralgia can both be relieved by using an external rub containing St. John's wort infused oil.

❗ **General cautions** Back problems need specialist care. For chronic or severe back pain, seek the advice of a professional practitioner to gain the most benefit from herbal medicine.

General Remedies

Herbs Cramp bark (*Viburnum opulus*, p. 150), prickly ash (*Zanthoxylum americanum*, p. 153)

Remedy Make a decoction using 15 g of cramp bark and 5 g of prickly ash bark to 3 cups (750 ml) of water. Strain and rub into the affected area, or use 1 tbsp of tincture and apply in the same way.

Note Use especially for tense neck and lumbar regions.

Herb Thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143)

Remedy Make an infusion using 25 g of herb to 3 cups (750 ml) of water and strain into a bath. Soak for 20 minutes.

Herbs St. John's wort (*Hypericum perforatum*, p. 106), lavender (*Lavandula officinalis*, p. 108), pepper (*Piper nigrum*, p. 250), cramp bark (*Viburnum opulus*, p. 150)

Remedy Take 2 tbsp of sunflower oil or St. John's wort infused oil, add 20 drops of lavender essential oil, 10 drops each of rosemary and pepper essential oil, and 1 tsp of cramp bark tincture. Shake and rub into tense areas, either after a bath or having first warmed the area with a hot towel.

Other uses Use for sciatica and other back problems that cause neuralgia, as well as for stiff joints and chronic muscle ache.

Back Pain due to Joint Inflammation

Herbs White willow (*Salix alba*, p. 129), cramp bark (*Viburnum opulus*, p. 150), devil's claw (*Harpagophytum procumbens*, p. 103)

Remedy Mix equal parts of each root and make a decoction. Divide into 6 doses and take over 2 days. If there is no improvement after 7 days, divide the decoction into 3 doses and take daily for up to a week.

Caution Do not take devil's claw during pregnancy.

Sleeplessness due to Backache

Herbs Passionflower (*Passiflora incarnata*, p. 119), valerian (*Valeriana officinalis*, p. 148), cramp bark (*Viburnum opulus*, p. 150)

Remedy Make a decoction using 8 g each of passionflower, valerian, and cramp bark to 3 cups (750 ml) of water and drink ¾–1 ¼ cup (150–300 ml) at night (the decoction is sufficient for 2 days).